

Right dislocation as multidominance, and beyond

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Abstract: This study argues for a multidominant approach to right dislocation (RD), the first of its kind, with data from Cantonese and Mandarin as well as Japanese and Korean. The crucial evidence comes from focus/*wh*-association of ‘only’/‘(wh-)the-hell’ expressions in RD, which requires a “leftward” c-command configuration. This challenges current monoclausal movement and biclausal sluicing approaches, but naturally falls out from a multidominant structure formed by Parallel Merge. The findings suggest that focus/*wh*-association serves as reliable and moreover novel diagnostics for multidominance, which can be extended beyond RD to Right Node Raising and possibly other constructions.

Keywords: *right dislocation, multidominance, focus/wh-association, only, wh-the-hell*

1 Introduction

Right dislocation (henceforth RD) refers to the phenomenon in which some elements are displaced or “copied” to the right of a sentence, which is commonly found in colloquial speech, such as *He’s real smart, John is* (Kayne 1994:78, see Ott & de Vries 2016 and references therein). In Chinese (including Cantonese and Mandarin), when sentence-final particles (SFPs) are present, the displaced elements must follow the SFPs as in (1) (Cheung 2009, 2015, Lee 2017, 2021, Tang 2015, 2018, Yip 2025, *i.a.*).

- (1) $\overbrace{[\dots (XP_i) \dots \text{SFP}]}^{\text{main chunk}} \quad \overbrace{XP_i}^{\text{RD chunk}}$

Two example are given in (2). The same pattern holds for other East Asian languages like Japanese (Tanaka 2001) and Korean (Park & Kim 2009).¹

¹RD in Chinese may also be gapless with a resumptive pronoun in the main chunk, like English (e.g., Chan 2016, Y. Chen 2016, Cheung 2015). In this paper, I focus only on gapped RD, but the observations and proposal developed here are equally applicable to gapless RD.

(2) (Gapped) right dislocation in Chinese

- a. [__ heoi-zo Meigwok laa3] **Aaming**.
 go-PFV US SFP Ming
 ‘Ming went to the US.’
 [Cantonese, CC]
- b. [__ qu-le Meiguo le] **Xiaoming**.
 go-PFV US SFP Ming
 ‘Ming went to the US.’
 [Mandarin, MC]

While RD has received very different accounts in the literature, all major approaches assume that there is some syntactic structure that remains unpronounced in the RD chunk:

- (3) [main chunk YP ZP] SFP [RD chunk XP ~~YP ZP~~]

The monoclausal approach proposes that the structure is derived via (leftward) movement with **Copy Deletion** (i.e., YP and ZP are deleted copies), as argued by Cheung (2009), Chiang (2017), Lee (2017, 2021), and Yip (2020), among others. The biclausal approach claims that the RD chunk is derived through **ellipsis** or **sluicing** (i.e., YP and ZP are elided/sluiced), following Cheung (2015), Tang (2015, 2018), and Yip (2025). Despite the apparent “rightward” displacement, it is of consensus that RD does not actually involve rightward movement, at least in Chinese. Rightward movement not only violates Linear Correspondence Axiom (LCA) (Kayne 1994) and theoretically undesirable, but it is also empirically unsupported in RD, as discussed by Cheung (2009) and Tanaka (2001), and later in this paper.²

The central question in this paper is what the nature of the silence in the RD chunk is. I argue that the silence is neither a result of movement nor sluicing. Rather, I propose that it arises from a **multidominant** structure created by **Parallel Merge** (Citko 2005), which, to the best of my knowledge, has not been discussed for RD. The crucial evidence comes from RD cases involving “only” and “the-hell” expressions, as illustrated in (4) and (5):

- (4) [Aaming _ zungji *nibun syu*_F zaa3] *zinghai*. (5) [_ *Shei* hui lai a] *daodi*?
Ming like this book SFP only who will come SFP the.hell
'Ming only likes *this book*.' [CC] 'Who the hell will come?' [MC]

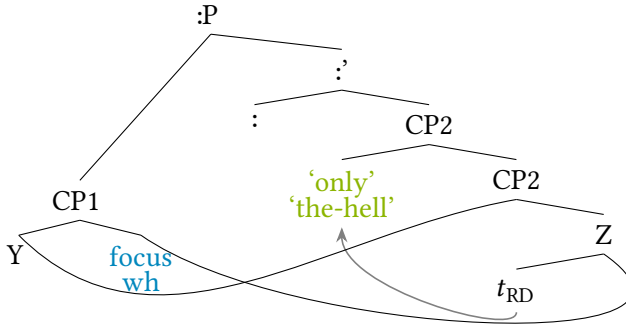
I will show that their association with focused/*wh*-elements serves as reliable diagnostics for multidominance, and applies beyond RD to other multidominant structures like Right Node Raising (RNR, Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023, Citko 2011, Grosz 2015, Wilder 1999, *i.a.*). This study is also the first to recruit such diagnostics for multidominance, and hence enriches our battery of tests for the nature of syntactic silence.

Specifically, I demonstrate that focus and *wh*-association requires the RD elements to **c-command** the main chunk in a leftward direction. Only a multidominant structure of RD can generate this correct structural relation, as proposed in (6). The “non-pronunciation” of elements in the RD chunk results from “node-sharing” or Parallel Merge (Citko 2005, Gračanin-Yuksek 2007, Wilder 1999). Movement and sluicing approaches fail to create the required c-command relation.

²See also Fernández-Sánchez (2017), Oney (2025), and Ott & de Vries (2016), among others, for arguments against rightward movement in RD in non-East Asian languages.

(6) A schematic multidominant structure of RD

(:P = specifying coordination, see fn.4)



The rest of the paper is organized as follows. §2 provides the background on different approaches to RD. §3 discusses the puzzle of focus and *wh*-association in RD. §4 proposes the multidominance account of RD and §5 offers arguments against rightward movement. §6 concludes with a parallel paradigm with RNR and some open questions.

2 Debate on the nature of syntactic silence in RD

A signature property of RD is that it is subject to island effects. First, the RD chunk and the gap (in the main chunk) may be separated by a CP boundary as in (7), showing long-distance displacement. Note that this example also indicates that (i) RD of adjuncts is possible (cf. subject RD in (2)), and (ii) there is no Right Right Roof Constraint in RD (see §5).

(7) RD can be long-distance

[CC, same in MC]

[Ngo zi [CP ZS _ maai-zo bou soenggei] aa3] hai dinnouzit.

1SG know ZS buy-PFV CL camera SFP at computer.festival

‘I know ZS bought a/the camera at the Computer Festival.’

(Lee 2017:64)

Yet, the RD chunk and the gap cannot be separated by an island boundary, as in (8).

(8) RD is subject to island effects

[CC, same in MC]

a. *[Ngo sik-saai [DP [CP _ zangging lyunlok-gwo] ge godi gongze] gaa], keoi.
1SG know-all already contact-EXP MOD those speaker SFP 3SG

Int.: ‘I know all the speakers that s/he contacted.’

(Complex NP island)

b. *[ZS [CP janwai _ maai-zo dinnou] soji mou cin sikfaan lo1] jung jingam.
ZS because buy-PFV computer so no money eat SFP with cash

Int.: ‘Because ZS bought a computer with cash, he has no money for meal.’

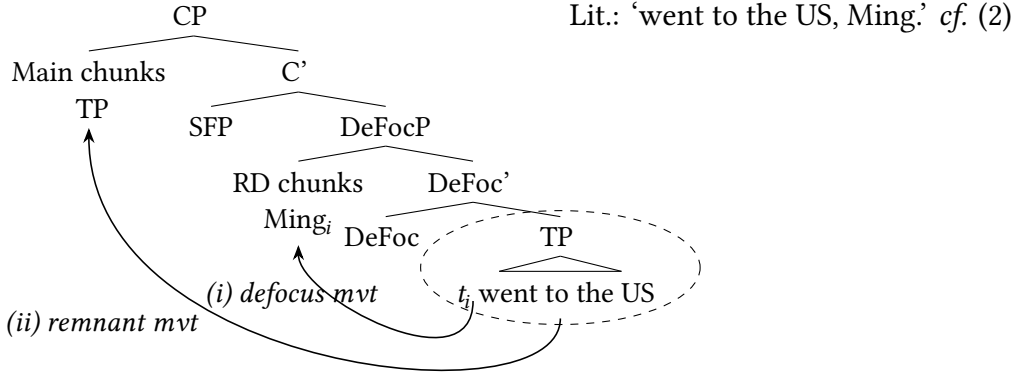
(Adjunct island; Lee 2017:65)

Precluding rightward movement, the RD chunks must contain some silent structure related to the main chunks syntactically, with either (i) a direct derivational relationship (e.g., movement) or (ii) an indirect parallelism requirement (e.g., from sluicing). This sets apart RD from two independent sentences like afterthoughts (see Ott & de Vries 2016, Wei & Li 2018, Yip 2020 for their differences).

The first option (i) leads to the monoclausal approach, which posits that RD consists of one

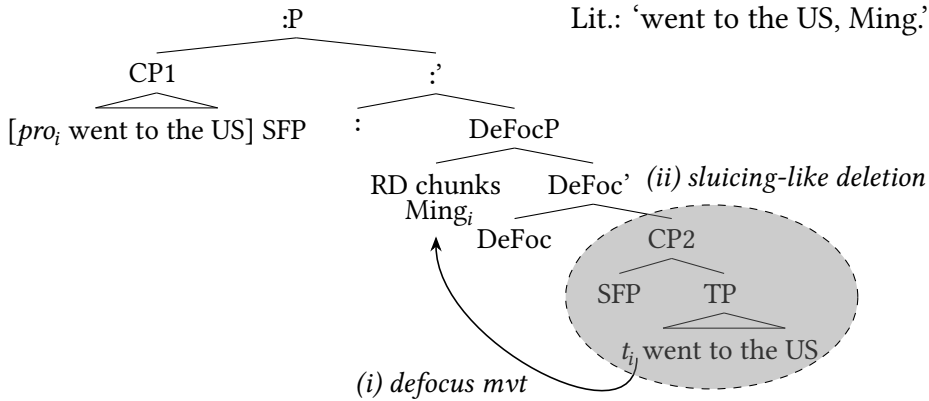
clause (Cheung 1997, 2009, Chiang 2017, Lee 2017, 2021, 2023, Wei & Li 2018, Yip 2020). The two chunks are derivationally related by movement: after the RD chunk moves to a position below SFPs (for defocus reasons), the remnant clause moves to a position above SFPs, forming the main chunk, as illustrated in (9).³ Note that SFPs are assumed to be head-initial (e.g., Pan 2022, Simpson & Wu 2002). Therefore, the apparent “rightward” displacement can be derived by leftward movement.

(9) The monoclausal + movement approach to RD (adopted from Lee 2017)



The second option (ii) leads to the biclausal approach, which, by contrast, analyzes the two chunks as two clauses base-generated on their own and then coordinated (Chan 2016, Y. Chen 2016, Cheung 2015, Dong 2018, Tang 2015, 2018, Yip 2025).⁴ The RD chunk involves sluicing, as illustrated in (10): after the RD element is moved to a higher position, the remnant clause is elided *per* a parallelism requirement with the main chunk. SFPs may be either head-initial or head-final. The gap in the main chunk is treated either as empty categories in argument RD or as non-existent in adjunct RD (i.e., no empty adverbs).

(10) The biclausal + sluicing approach to RD (Yip 2025)



Empirically, both approaches capture the core movement properties of RD by a shared defocus movement. Yet, the silent remnant clause in the RD chunk is analyzed very differently: either as traces or as elided materials. This begs the question of how to diagnose the nature of syntactic silence.

³DeFocP is a projection for defocus/anti-focus [-Foc], elements that resist alternative-based focus (e.g., contrastive, exclusive, *wh*-question-answer). See Lee (2020).

⁴Ott & de Vries (2016) propose that RD involves a specifying coordination : (colon), with the second clause “specifying the first by adding relevant information to it” (p.649).

3 The puzzle of focus/*wh*-association

First, as long noticed, ‘only/the-hell’ expressions have a peculiar c-command requirement as in (11) (for ‘only,’ see Beaver & Clark 2008, Erlewine 2014, 2017, Jackendoff 1972, Tancredi 1990; for ‘the-hell’ in Mandarin and Japanese, see Huang & Ochi 2004).

- (11) The focus/*wh*-association constraint

'Only/the-hell' expressions must *c-command* the **pronounced** copy of their focus/*wh*-associate.

‘Only/the-hell,’ however, can be right-dislocated and still associate “leftward” with the focus/*wh* in the main chunk, as in (4) above and (12) below. This is first observed in Cheung (1997), with further discussion in Cheung (2009, 2015) and Yip (2020, 2025). The same holds for *wh*-association with *doudai/daodi* ‘the-hell’ when right-dislocated, as we have seen in (5). Another example is given in (13).⁵

- (12) Focus association with ‘only’ right-dislocated [CC, same in MC]

[*Aaming*_F wui lai zaa3] **zinghai**.

Ming will come SFP only

‘(Only) *Ming* will come, only’

(Subj focus)

- (13) *Wh*-association with ‘(wh)-the-hell’ right-dislocated [CC, same in MC]

[Aaming zungji *[binbun syu]*_F aa3] **doudai?**

Ming like which book sfp the.hell

‘After all, which book does Ming like?’

(*Wh*-Obj)

This pattern is also true in Japanese and Korean.

- (14) [*Dare*-ga ki-ta n-da], *ittai?* [Japanese]

who-NOM come-PST NMLZ-COP the.hell

‘Who the hell came?’

(Yusuke Yagi, p.c.)

- (15) a. [Ku salam-i *nwukwu*-ya] *totaychey*? [Korean]

that person-NOM — who-INT the.hell

‘Who the hell is that person?’

(Florence Zhang, Yumin Ji, p.c.)

- b. [Minswu-nun *Chelswu*_F-man(-ul) manna-ss-eyo], **oloci**.

Minsu-TOP Cheolsu-only-ACC meet-PST-HON only

‘Minsu only met Cheolsu.’

(Florence Zhang, Yumin Ji, p.c.)

Given the association constraint (11), the puzzle is how ‘only/the hell’ can c-command the focus/*wh* in the main chunk **leftward**, as in (16). As will be shown below, both monoclausal movement and biclausal sluicing approaches fail to create this c-command relation.

- (16) The required licensing configuration of focus/*wh*-association in RD

[main ... *focus/wh* ...] SFP [RD '*only*'/'*the hell*']
 ↑ c-command |

⁵Cheung (2009) notes that RD of *zhi* ‘only’ in Mandarin is marginally acceptable. Yet, with disyllabic *zhishi* ‘only, just’, the judgment is significantly improved (see also Dong 2018:25). I set aside the difference here.

3.1 Movement of the associates fails

As a cross-linguistically robust phenomenon, ‘only’ must c-command its focus associates (Beaver & Clark 2008, Erlewine 2014, Jackendoff 1972, Tancredi 1990). When the focused element moves out, ‘only’ cannot associate with it. This pattern holds for all kinds of movement: A-movement such as raising and passivization, and A’-movement such as topicalization in (17a) and relativization. Moving out the *wh*-associate of ‘the-hell’ even yields ungrammaticality (Cheung 2009, Huang & Ochi 2004), as in (17b).

- (17) Focus/*wh*-association fails with topicalization [CC, same in MC]
- a. *[*Ni zek gau*]_F, Aaming *zinghai* m-zungji __.
 this CL dog Ming only not-like
 Int.: ‘Ming only doesn’t like *this dog*.’ (ONLY: ‘This dog, Ming only doesn’t like.’)
- b. *[*Bin zek gau*]_F, Aaming *doudai* m-zungji __?
 which CL dog Ming the.hell not-like
 Int.: ‘(After all,) which dog does Ming not like?’

This shows a sharp contrast with reflexive binding. A’-movement such as topicalization reconstructs the moved reflexives to the gap position.

- (18) Reconstruction for reflexive binding in topicalization [CC, same in MC]
- a. [*keoizigei_k zek gau*]_i, Aaming_k hou zungji ___i gaa3
 3SG.self CL dog Ming very like SFP
 Lit.: ‘Himself_k’s dog, Ming_k only likes.’ (i.e. Ming_k likes his_k dog.)
- b. [*Bin zek keoizigei_k ge gau*]_i, Aaming_k zeoi zungji ___i aa3?
 which CL 3SG.self GE dog Ming most like SFP
 ‘Which dog of himself_k does Ming_k like the most?’

Yet, when the reflexive is contained in a focus/*wh*-associate, reconstruction is not possible.

- (19) Reconstruction fails with focus/*wh*-association [CC, same in MC]
- a. *[*Keoizigei_k zek gau*]_{F_i}, Aaming_k *zinghai* zungji ___i gaa3
 3SG.self CL dog Ming only like SFP
 Lit.: ‘Himself_k’s dog, Ming_k only likes.’
 Int.: ‘Ming_k only likes his_k own dog (lit.: himself_k’s dog).’
- b. *[*Bin zek keoizigei_k ge gau*]_i, Aaming_k *doudai* zeoi zungji ___i aa3?
 which CL 3SG.self GE dog Ming the.hell most like SFP
 Int.: ‘(After all,) which dog of himself_k does Ming_k like the most?’

The mechanism responsible for reconstruction for binding, which is standardly assumed to be the interpretation of the lower copy in the Logical Form (LF), fails to license the focus and *wh*-association. If RD were derived by the same syntactic movement mechanism (as Cheung 2009, Lee 2017 argue), then movement of the focus and *wh*-associates across ‘only’ and ‘the hell’ (*via* remnant movement) should have been disallowed, contrary to fact.

Since movement of focus and *wh*-associates fails independently, the silence in RD chunks cannot be due to movement or Copy Deletion. Moreover, no correct c-command relation can be created for focus or *wh*-association.⁶

- (20) The illicit configuration created by monoclausal movement approaches

$$^*[\text{CP} [\text{TP} \dots \text{focus/wh} \dots] \text{C-SFP} [\text{DeFocP} \dots \text{'only'/'the hell'} \dots \text{ } ^*[\text{TP} \dots \text{focus/wh} \dots] \dots]]$$
but fails to associate with traces

3.2 Ellipsis/sluicing of the associates fails

The biclausal sluicing approach is no better than the monoclausal movement approach. Focus association fails in VP ellipsis with the associate elided, as already noted in Cheung (2009) and exemplified in (21).⁷ Only when ‘only’ is elided altogether is it fine; if ‘only’ is pronounced, the result is ungrammatical. This property of ‘only’ is general to other languages, as discussed by Bassi, Hirsch & Trinh (2022) and Beaver & Clark (2008).

- (21) Focus association fails in VP ellipsis [CC, same in MC]
- a. Aaming **zinghai** wui maai *siusyut*_F. *Aafan dou **zinghai** wui [_{VP} maai *siusyut*_F]
 Ming only will buy novel Fan also only will
 Int.: ‘Ming will only buy novels. Fan as well.’
- b. Aaming wui **zinghai** maai *siusyut*_F. Aafan dou wui [_{VP} ~~zinghai maai~~ *siusyut*_F]
 Ming will only buy novel Fan also will
 ‘Ming will only buy novels. Fan as well.’

Nevertheless, Cheung (2015) suggests that deletion in RD involves “PF sluicing” ($\neq$ ellipsis; Merchant 2001), which might provide a potential explanation for the exceptional licensing of focus/*wh*-association in RD. Yet, I will show that other sluicing-like constructions in Chinese also disallow focus/*wh*-association, just like VP ellipsis. Consider fragment questions first, where interrogative *wh*-words can be deleted (*cf.* Li 2015 for Mandarin). The fragment question in (22c) consists of a contrastive topic, and optionally an adverbial.

- (22) Interrogative *wh*-words elided in fragment questions [CC, same in MC]
- | | |
|--|---|
| a. Aaming tingjat wui heoi bindou ?
Ming tomorrow will go where
'Where will Ming go tomorrow?' | c. Gam Aafan (tingjat) ne?
then Fan tomorrow TOP
'What about Fan (tomorrow)?' (i.e.,
Where will Fan go tomorrow?) |
| b. Tousyugun.
library 'Library.' | d. Hokhaau.
school 'School.' |

⁶Two clarifications on movement are needed. First, I do *not* assume Remerger: abundant evidence from partial Copy Deletion supports the Copy Theory of Movement (Bošković & Nunes 2007, Lee & Yip 2025, van Urk 2018, Yip & Ahenkorah 2023), and even with Remerger one must explain why RD differs from other movements. Second, I reject PF movement for RD (Cheung 2011). Gapless RD requires movement in Narrow Syntax to yield copying effects (Lee 2021), but it still permits focus/*wh*-association (Cheung 2015).

⁷Note that (interrogative) *wh*-words cannot be elided in VP ellipsis, independently.

Wei (2018) argues that fragment questions in Chinese are derived by movement and deletion (i.e., sluicing). Importantly, fragment questions, unlike regular movement, have selective island repair effects—only complex NPs and adjuncts constitute islands, but not left branches (SpecDP) and sentential subjects—which supports the PF sluicing approach.

- (23) [CP Question fragment [TP ...  ...]]

Now, we have a construction comparable to the biclausal sluicing approach of RD to test whether focus/*wh*-association survives in sluicing. As in (24), the answer is no.

- (24) Wh association fails in fragment questions [CC, same in MC]
- a. Aaming **doudai** wui heoi *bindou*?
Ming the.hell will go where
'Where the hell will Ming go?'
- b. Tousyugun.
library 'Library.'
- c. *Gam Aafan **doudai** ne?
then Fan the.hell TOP
Int.: 'What about Fan?'

Verbal echo answers containing an adverbial like (25) are also argued to be derived by sluicing-like operations with movement and deletion (Z. Chen 2022, Simpson 2014). In (26), however, focus association fails.

- | | | |
|------|---|---|
| (25) | <u>Verbal echo answers</u>
a. Aaming sengjat tai nibun syu gaa4?
Ming often read this book SFP
'Does Ming often read this book?' | [CC, same in MC]
b. Sengjat tai.
often read
'Ming often reads this book.' |
| (26) | <u>Focus association fails in verbal echo answers</u>
a. Aaming zinghai tai [nibun syu] _F gaa4?
Ming only read this book SFP
'Does Ming only read this book?' | [CC, same in MC]
b. *Zinghai tai.
only read
Int.: 'Ming only reads this book.' |

Since ellipsis/slueing of focus/*wh*-associate fails independently, Cheung (2015)’s “PF sluicing” cannot explain the exceptional licensing of focus and *wh* associations in RD. Again, no correct c-command relation can be created, as illustrated in (27).

- (27) The illicit configuration created by biclausal sluicing approaches

$$*[\text{CP}_1 \dots \text{focus/wh} \dots] \text{ SFP } [\text{CP}_2 \dots \text{'only'/'the hell'} \dots \text{focus/wh} \dots \text{SFP}]$$

but fails to associate with elided materials

4 Right dislocation as multidominance

I propose that RD involves a *multidominant* structure. I follow Ott & de Vries (2016) and Yip (2025) and assume that RD has two clauses which are coordinated by :P (specifying coordination), with defocus movement in CP2. Unlike their sluicing analysis, however, I argue that CP1 and CP2 are derivationally related, in the sense that their nodes are shared, or, precisely, undergo Parallel Merge (after Citko 2005), as specified in (28).

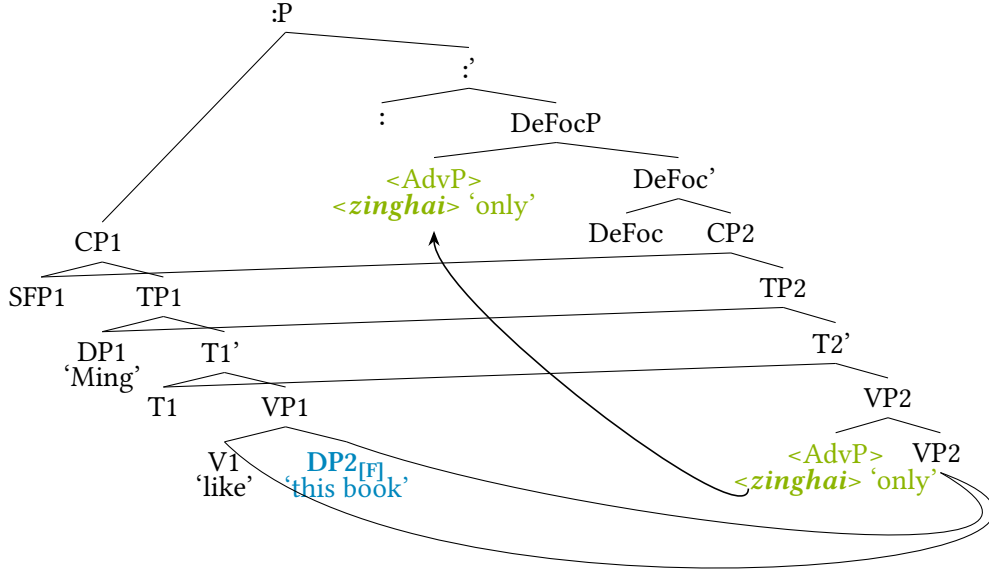
(28) Multidominance in right dislocation

CP2 shares every (non-branching) node with CP1 except for the defocused element(s) that undergo(es) movement.

An illustration is given in (30) for (29) (reproduced from (4)).

- (29) [Aaming _ zungji [*nibun syu*]_F zaa3] *zinghai*. [CC]
 Ming like this book SFP only
 ‘Ming (only) likes *this book*, only.’

- (30) A derivation of RD of adverb ‘only’ (‘Ming likes *this book*, only.’)



All the non-branching nodes in the two CPs are shared and pronounced once in the main chunk, whereas the defocused element is moved higher to DefocP without node sharing, and pronounced in the RD chunk. In other words, the syntactic “silence” in CP2 is illusional. There are no true silent materials in CP2 (excluding the defocused element)—they are just pronounced before the RD chunk as the main chunks, which are simultaneously part of CP1 and CP2.⁸

Parallel Merge has been proven successful accounting for other coordinated structures, including Right Node Raising (Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023, Wilder 1999), ATB *wh*-movement (Citko 2005, de Vries 2009), and conjoined *wh*-questions (Citko & Gračanin-Yuksek 2013, Gračanin-Yuksek 2007), among others. (30) involves “non-bulk sharing”, where the shared nodes do not form a constituent. This notion is independently motivated by conjoined *wh*-questions like the sort in (31) (Gračanin-Yuksek 2007).

- (31) a. **What and where** did Kelly drink?
 b. [&P [CP1 What Δ Δ Δ] and [CP2 where Δ Δ Δ]]? (structure simplified)
 did Kelly drink

⁸For present purposes, I assume all shared nodes are linearized/ordered before the non-shared ones in RD.

While previous studies provided various arguments for the necessity of multidominance, a novel perspective here is that multidominance essentially creates new structural relations to feed focus/*wh*-association. This is what ellipsis/slucing fails to do, which leaves the structure intact. Movement also leaves the launching site intact, at least under the Copy Theory of Movement. In contrast, under Wilder (1999: ex.18-21)’s definition of c-command for multidominant structures in (32), *zinghai* in (30) c-commands DP2 ‘this book’, shared by VP1 and VP2. Recall that ‘only/the-hell’ must c-command an *overt* associate (cf. (11)). Although DP2 is pronounced in the main chunk, *zinghai* in the RD chunk still c-commands it. Multidominance hence delivers the required licensing configuration for association in (33).

- (32) a. Sharing: α is shared by X and Y iff (i) neither of X and Y dominates the other, and (ii) both X and Y dominate α .
 b. Full dominance: X fully dominates α iff X dominates α and X does not share α .
 c. C-command: X c-commands α iff (i) $X \neq \alpha$, (ii) X does not *fully* dominate α , (iii) α does not dominate X, and (iv) all categories that dominate X dominate α .

- (33) Multidominance creates the required c-command relation in RD

$$\begin{array}{c} \text{[main ... focus/wh ...] SFP [RD 'only'/'the hell']} \\ \uparrow \text{c-command} \end{array}$$

5 Against rightward movement

An alternative to capture the “leftward” c-command relations in RD is by a “what you see is what you get” analysis as in (34): SFPs are head-final, and RD chunks move rightward from main chunks, which then c-command the main chunks. Rightward movement in RD has been pursued in some languages, like Hindi-Urdu and Bangla (Bhatt & Dayal 2007; but see Simpson & Choudhury 2015) and Japanese (Simon 1989; but see Tanaka 2001).

- (34)
$$\begin{array}{c} \text{[CP [C' [TP t focus/wh] SFP] 'only/the.hell']} \\ \uparrow \end{array}$$

However, rightward movement is both theoretically and empirically undesirable. As mentioned before, it violates the LCA (Kayne 1994). Moreover, treating Chinese SFPs as head-final would violate the Final-over-Final Condition, since Chinese verbal domains are head-initial (see also Simpson & Wu 2002 for evidence that SFPs are head-initial).

Empirically, RD does not obey the constraints found in other rightward movement dependencies, such as the Right Roof Constraint (RRC) exemplified in (35).

- (35) Right Roof Constraint in rightward extraposition (Ross 1967:166)
 a. [That [a review __] came out yesterday [of this article]_i] is catastrophic.
 b. *[That [a review __] came out yesterday] is catastrophic [of this article]_i.

We have seen from (7) that RD can be long-distance, reproduced in (36a). Note that the SFP *aa3* cannot be embedded, indicating that the landing site is at the root level. This demonstrates that no RRC is in effect. Linear order does not play a role either. It is possible to right-dislocate a matrix material even when there is an embedded clause as in (36b).

- (36) a. [Ngo zi [CP ZS _ maai-zo bou soenggei] aa3] hai dinnouzit. [CC]
 1SG know ZS buy-PFV CL camera SFP at computer.festival
 ‘I know ZS bought a/the camera at the Computer Festival.’ (Lee 2017:64)
- b. [_ zidou [CP ZS hai dinnouzit maai-zo bou soenggei] aa3] ngo.
 know ZS at computer.festival buy-PFV CL camera SFP 1SG
 ‘I know ZS bought a/the camera at the Computer Festival.’

Last but not least, this alternative relies on a monoclausal structure with a trace in main chunks, which Yip (2025) shows to be empirically flawed. The gaps in main chunks are not movement-derived, since no reconstruction is possible in cases of variable binding and licensing of universal *wh*, ‘even’-focus, and NPIs. The gaps are instead empty categories, as supported by a typological correlation: languages with null arguments (e.g. East Asian) permit subject/object gapped RD, while those without (e.g. Germanic) require resumptive pronouns. (See Yip 2025 for more arguments and rebuttal to monoclausal approaches.) Under a biclausal structure, rightward movement fails to derive the needed configuration for focus/*wh*-association, since the RD chunk in CP2 cannot c-command CP1.

6 Prospects: extension to RNR and open questions

To conclude, evidence from focus and *wh*-association with ‘only’ and ‘the-hell’ supports a *novel* multidominant approach to right dislocation in Cantonese and Mandarin, extendable to Japanese and Korean. Apparent syntactic “silence” in RD chunks arises from node-sharing/Parallel Merge (Citko 2005, Gračanin-Yuksek 2007), not Copy Deletion (after movement) or ellipsis. Crucially, only multidominance creates the structural relation required for the association, which in turn serves as a reliable diagnostic, corroborated by its presence in other multidominant constructions such as Right Node Raising (Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023, Wilder 1999; see Yip & Tamar-Mattis 2025 for focus association in RNR):

- (37) Focus association of *only* in RNR
- a. John **only** likes __, and Mary also **only** likes, **THIS BOOK_F**.
- b. [Aaming **zinghai** zungji _] ji [Aafan (**zinghai**) toujim **gobun syu_F**] [CC]
 Ming only like but Fan only hate that book
 ‘Ming only likes, but Fan (only) hates, *that book*.’

However, there are still outstanding issues. One concerns linearization of “non-bulk sharing” in RD, which differs from conjoined *wh*-questions in whether shared nodes follow non-shared ones (Gračanin-Yuksek 2007). Another involves cross-linguistic variation, since not all languages permit focus/*wh*-association in RD (e.g., *JOHN_F read every book, only* in English cannot mean ‘Only John read every book’). I leave these issues to future research.

Abbreviations

1,2,3 = first, second, third persons; ACC = accusative; CL = classifier; COP = copula; HON = honorific; INT = interrogative; NMLZ = nominalizer; NOM = nominative; PFV = perfective; PST = past tense; SFP = sentence-final particle; SG = singular; TOP = topic.

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